

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

School leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above

In 2024, 76 percent of school leavers achieved NCEA Level 2 or above. This is an increase of 0.6 percentage points from 2023.

Indicator description

Percentage of school leavers with at least an NCEA Level 2 qualification or equivalent.¹

Why attaining NCEA Level 2 is important

The National Certificate of Educational Achievement Level 2 (NCEA Level 2) is the second stage of upper-secondary education and serves as a foundation for further study and/or employment. NCEA Level 2, as with all levels of NCEA, encompasses a wide range of learning. Students can attain credits through internal and external assessment, and they can accumulate these credits both within and across years.

The attainment of an upper secondary school qualification is linked to labour force status and income levels. For most individuals, attainment of at least NCEA Level 2 is the minimum qualification for successful labour-market participation (OECD, 2024).

Every year around 60,000 young people leave school and face choices about what to do next. Not being in employment, further education, or training (NEET) affects around 30% of school leavers overall in the first year after they finish school. School leavers who leave school without at least NCEA Level 2 are more likely to be in this group – almost 50% for leavers with NCEA Level 1 and almost 70% for leavers with no qualification, compared to around one-third for leavers with NCEA Level 2².

Research by Scott (2018) found that leavers with NCEA Level 2 are slightly more likely to go directly into work than leavers who have completed NCEA Level 3 or University Entrance, who are slightly more likely to enrol in a tertiary institution when they leave school. The group leaving with NCEA Level 2 has more accumulated earnings in the first 7 years after leaving school than the leavers with University Entrance. While there is not much difference between earnings for NCEA Level 2 and Level 3 groups, those with NCEA Level 1 school achievement have earned 15% less than their peers with NCEA Level 2, and those with no achievement are earning 51% less. (Scott, 2018).

¹ Equivalent attainment includes attainment of NCEA Level 2 standard from assessments outside the New Zealand Qualifications Framework. Examples of alternative assessments are: International Baccalaureate, Cambridge International exams and Accelerated Christian Education.

² Data covers school leavers from 2010-2020 inclusive. Results are derived from the Integrated Data Infrastructure (IDI) managed by Stats NZ and are not official statistics. For more information, please visit <https://www.stats.govt.nz/integrated-data/>.

How are we going

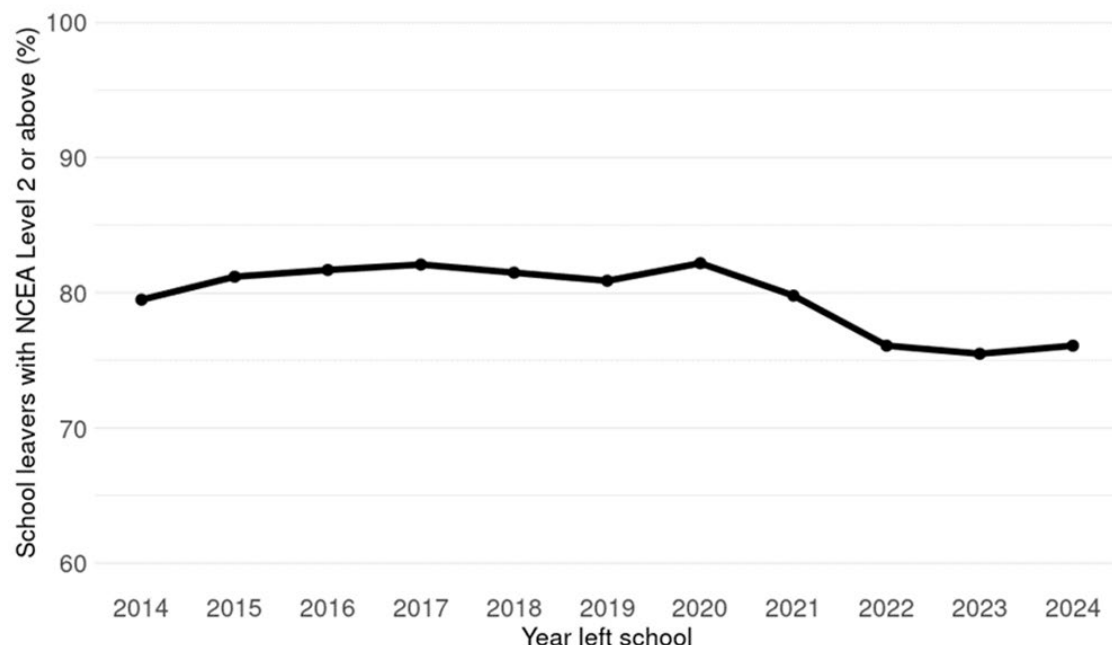
In 2024, 76.1% (51,286) of school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above, an increase of 0.6 percentage points (75.5% in 2023). Attainment of NCEA Level 2 peaked in 2020 at 82.2% and has decreased by 6.1 percentage points since then as shown in Figure 1.

In 2024, female (77.8%) school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above than their male (74.5%) counterparts.

Asian (87.1%) school leavers had the highest attainment rates for NCEA Level 2 or above, followed by European/Pākehā (78.2%), Pacific (71.1%), and then Māori (60.7%).

Schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement have higher attainment rates. In 2024, 93.6% of leavers from schools where students have the fewest barriers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 57.8% of leavers from schools where students have the most barriers.

Figure 1: The attainment rate for NCEA Level 2 or above increased in 2024

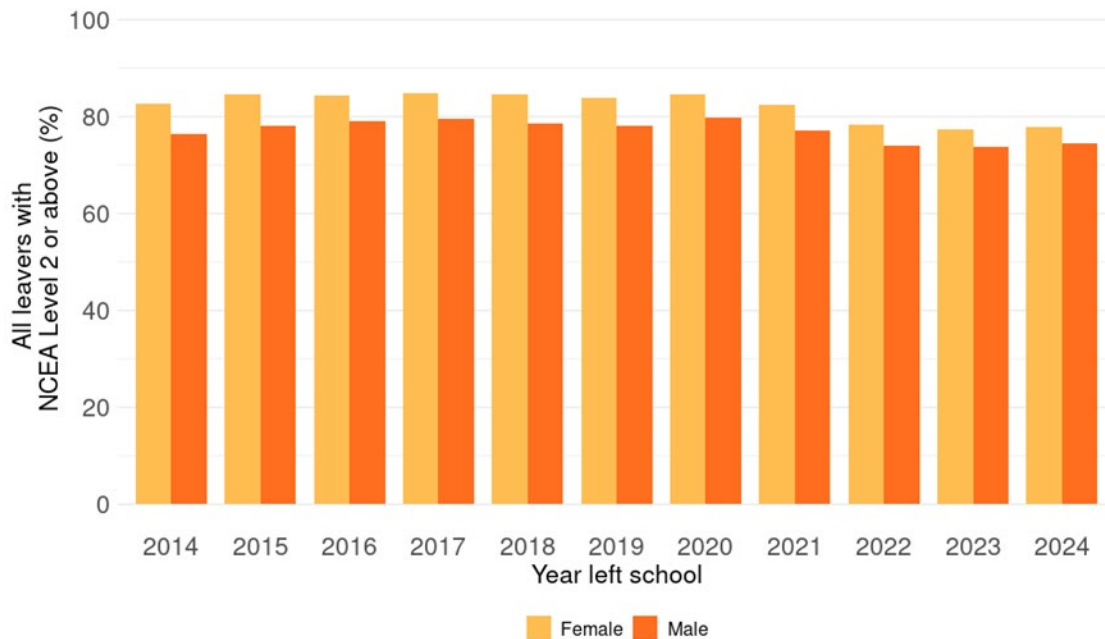


Gender

Since 2014, NCEA Level 2 or above attainment has been higher for female school leavers (Figure 2).

In 2024, 77.8% of female leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 74.5% of male leavers. This is an increase of 0.5 percentage points for female leavers and an increase of 0.8 percentage points for male leavers since 2023. This has decreased the gender gap from 3.6 percentage points in 2023 to 3.3 percentage points in 2024.



Figure 2: The gender gap in leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased over time

Socioeconomic barriers³

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates and a higher variability of attainment rates within the School Equity Index Bands. This indicates that there is an association between NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates and socioeconomic background.

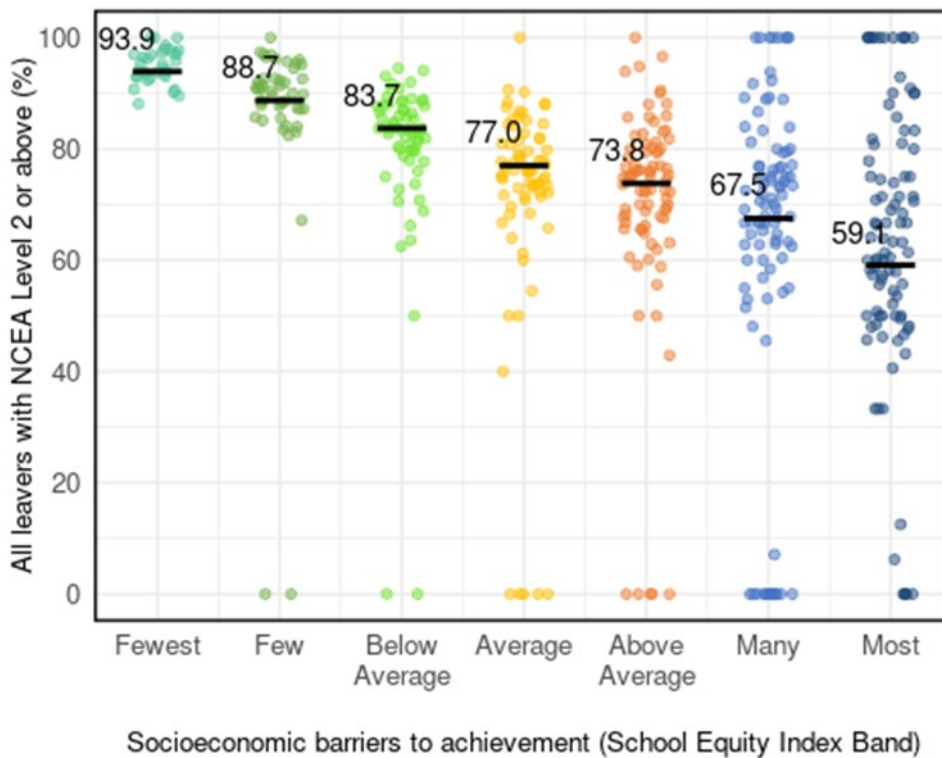
In 2024, schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement had an NCEA Level 2 attainment rate of 93.9%, and those where students have the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 59.1%.

Figure 3 shows the distribution of NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates for school leavers in 2024, by School Equity Index Band. There is variation in the percentage of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 2 or above among schools within each School Equity Index Band. This variation from the average increases with barriers to achievement. Schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement have less school-to-school variation from the average, as shown by the dots that are scattered closer to the band average. Schools where students have more barriers to achievement have higher between school variations in attainment rates, with a sizeable number of schools at either end of the range from 0% to 100%. Within each band, there are schools that have higher attainment rates while others have disproportionately low attainment rates.

³ For more information about the School Equity Index reporting see the section at the end of this indicator report.

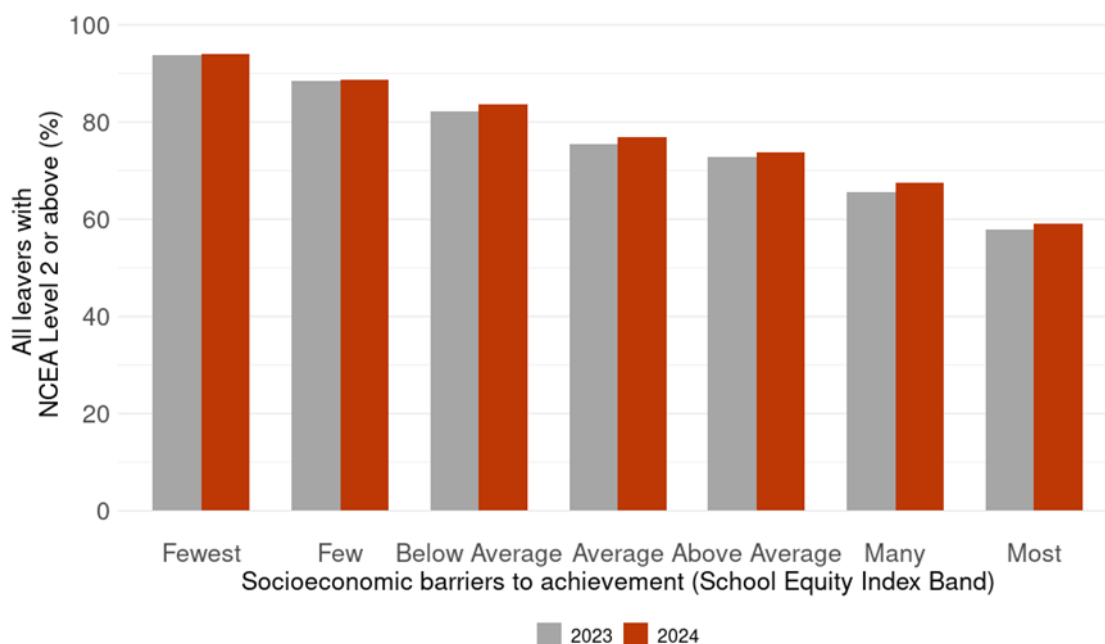


Figure 3: The proportion of school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above varies between schools within each School Equity Index Band



Compared to 2023, in 2024 across every band, a higher proportion of school leavers left school with NCEA Level 2 or above as shown in Figure 4. The highest increase in attainment was in schools where students have many barriers to achievement where attainment increased from 65.6% in 2023 to 67.5% in 2024.

Figure 4: The proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 2 or above in 2024 has increased in every School Equity Index Band compared to 2023



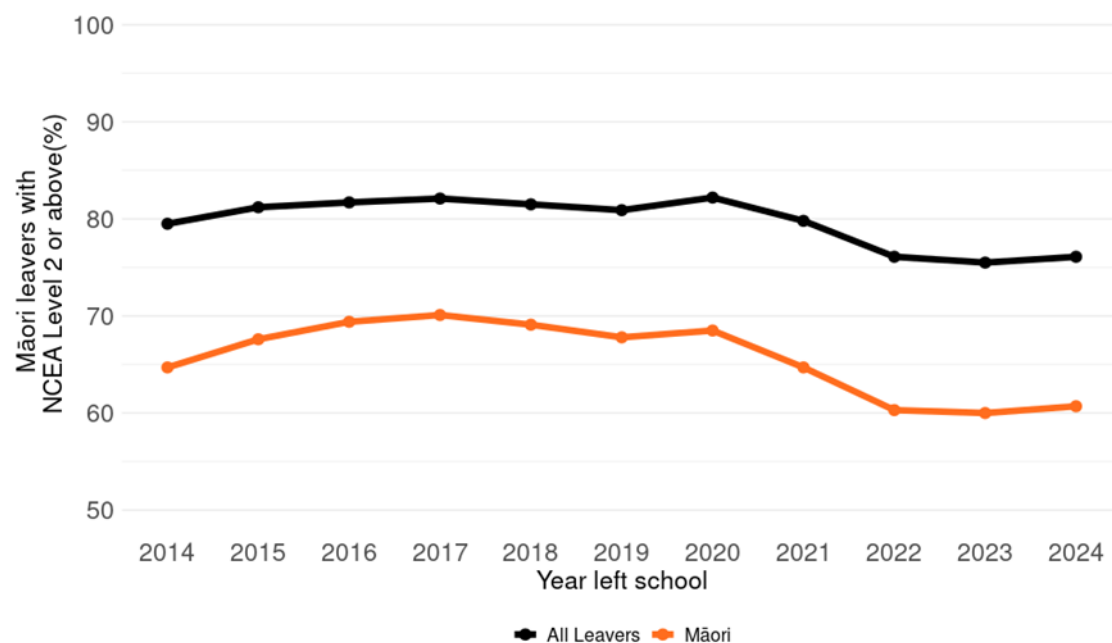
Ethnicity⁴

Compared to 2023 the proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 2 or above in 2024 was varied across all ethnic groupings. Pacific and Māori attainment rates increased slightly, rates for Asian leavers declined while rates for European/Pākehā leavers remained unchanged.

Māori school leavers

In 2024, 10,228 Māori school leavers (60.7%) attained NCEA Level 2 or above (shown in Figure 5). Between 2017 (the peak attainment for Māori leavers) and 2024, the attainment rate for NCEA Level 2 decreased by 9.4 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 7.1 percentage points. In 2024 the gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between Māori school leavers and for all school leavers decreased to 15.4 percentage points, down 0.1 percentage points from 2023.

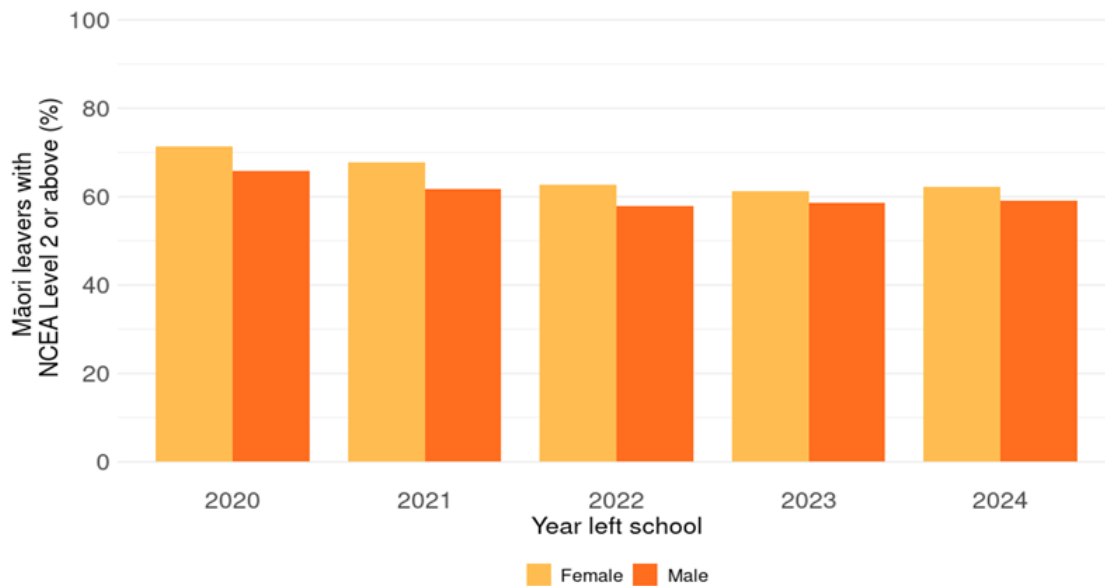
Figure 5: Māori school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above increased in 2024



In 2024, 62.1 % of Māori female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 59.2% of Māori male school leavers; up 0.8 and 0.5 percentage points from 2023 for female and male school leavers respectively as shown in Figure 6. The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between females and males decreased from 5.4 percentage points in 2020, to 2.6 percentage points in 2023 and slightly increasing to 2.9 percentage points in 2024.

⁴ Total response ethnicity counts students who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.



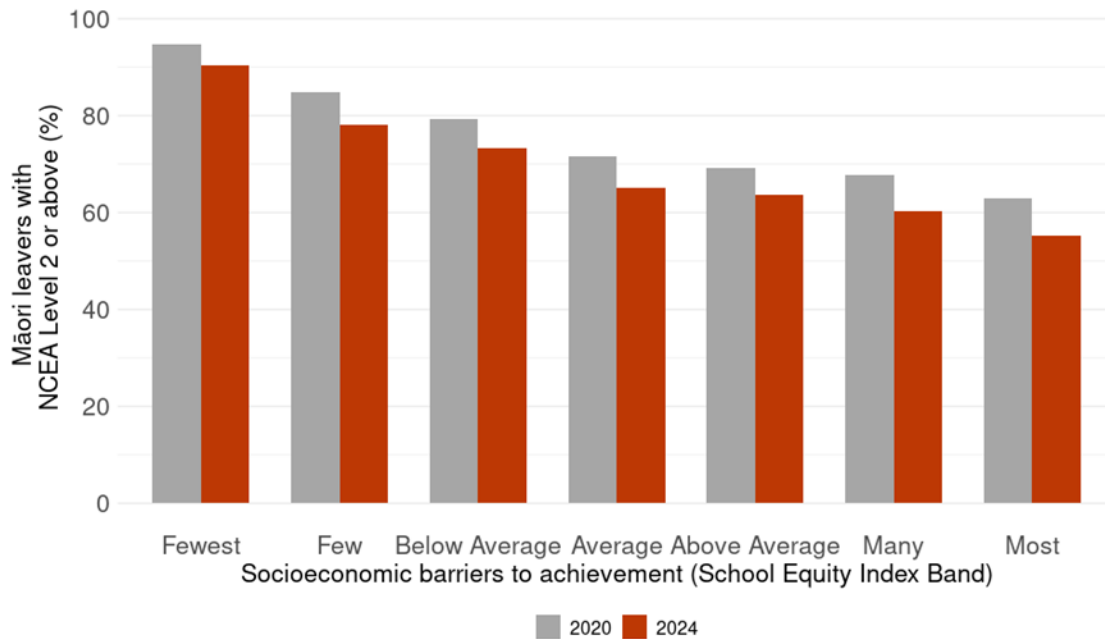
Figure 6: Māori female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above

Māori school leavers from schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement are more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above. In 2024, 90.5% of Māori leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 compared to 55.3% of Māori leavers from schools where students have most barriers to achievement. The NCEA Level 2 or above attainment gap between school leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement and those from schools where students have most barriers to achievement has become wider over time from 31.8 percentage points in 2020 to 36.6 percentage points in 2023 and declining slightly to 35.2 percentage points in 2024 (Figure 7).

While the five-year range shows a decline in attainment across all School Equity Index bands for Māori leavers, the attainment rates show an improvement between 2023 and 2024, except for schools where students have few barriers to achievement where NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates declined from 79.8% in 2023 to 78.1% in 2024.



Figure 7: The proportion of Māori school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands since 2020



Māori and language of learning⁵

Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

Of the 16,861 ākonga Māori who left school in 2024, 5% (835 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori, an increase of 74.7% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

Note that when looking at statistics based on small populations, such as the small number of school leavers learning in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in the proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

In 2024, 78.4% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 2 or above, up 3.7 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori and all school leavers increased to 2.3 percentage points in 2024 (78.4% and 76.1% respectively). In the last 10 years the difference has been as large as 3.9 percentage points (in 2017) and as low as 0.3 percentage points (in 2016). In 2024, this gap was the result of a higher attainment rate for Māori leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori compared to the rate for all leavers, unlike in previous years (Figure 8).

⁵ The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.



Māori predominantly learning in English

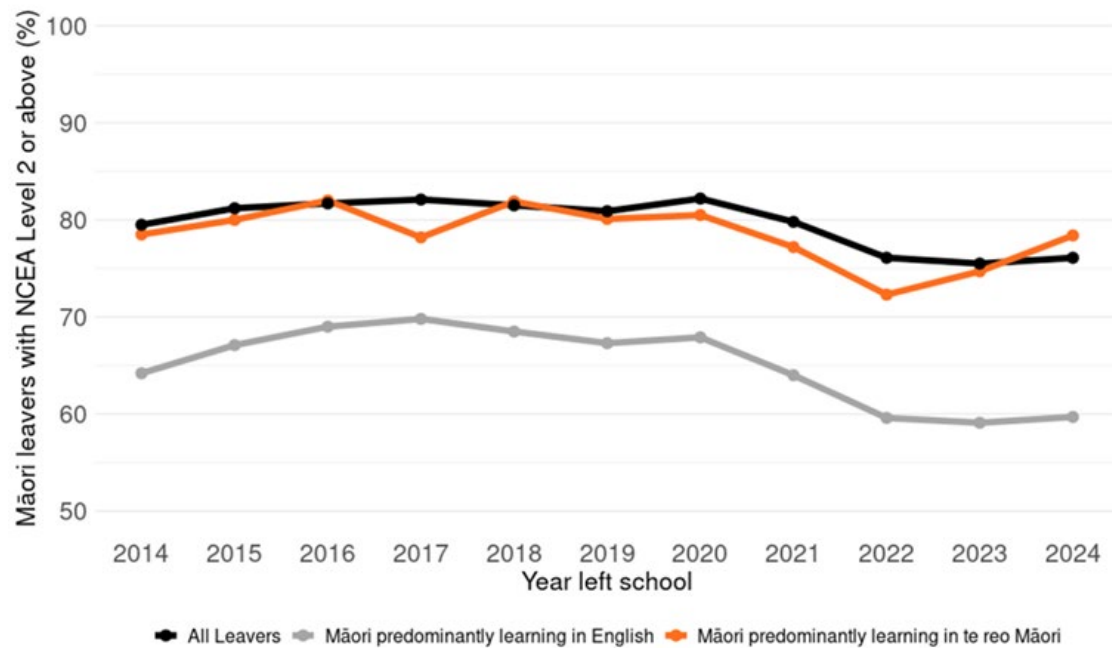
The NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rate for Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English was 59.7%, up 0.6 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English and all school leavers remained unchanged at 16.4 percentage points from 2023 to 2024.

Figure 8 also shows that attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above for school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori was comparable to all leavers' attainment across 2014 to 2024. In contrast, Māori school leavers predominantly learning in English consistently had lower attainment rates over the same period.

In 2024, Māori leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori outperformed the national average as well as Māori leavers learning predominantly in English. This is consistent with the findings by Smith et. al (2020) that connection with identity, language and culture has large effects on NCEA outcomes for ākonga Māori as shown by higher attainment for ākonga Māori learning in te reo Māori.

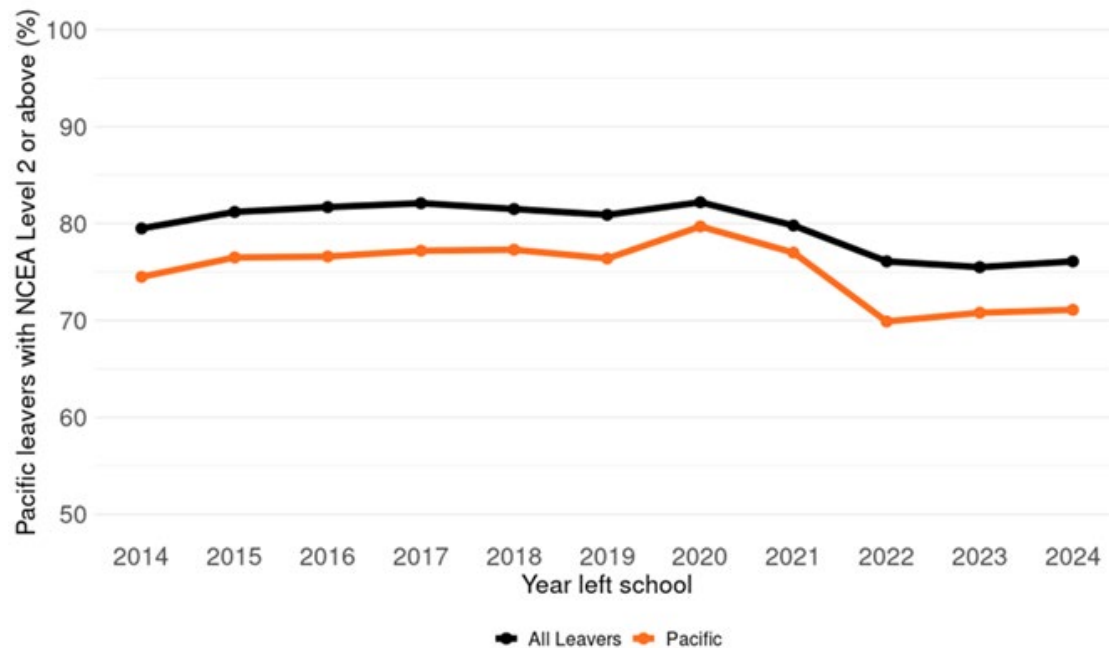
Figure 8: A higher proportion of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 2 or above



Pacific school leavers

In 2024, 6,133 (71.1%) of Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above, up 0.4 percentage points from 2023. As shown in Figure 9, the NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates for Pacific school leavers is lower than the rate for all leavers since 2014. Between 2020 (the peak attainment for Pacific leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 8.6 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.3 percentage points.

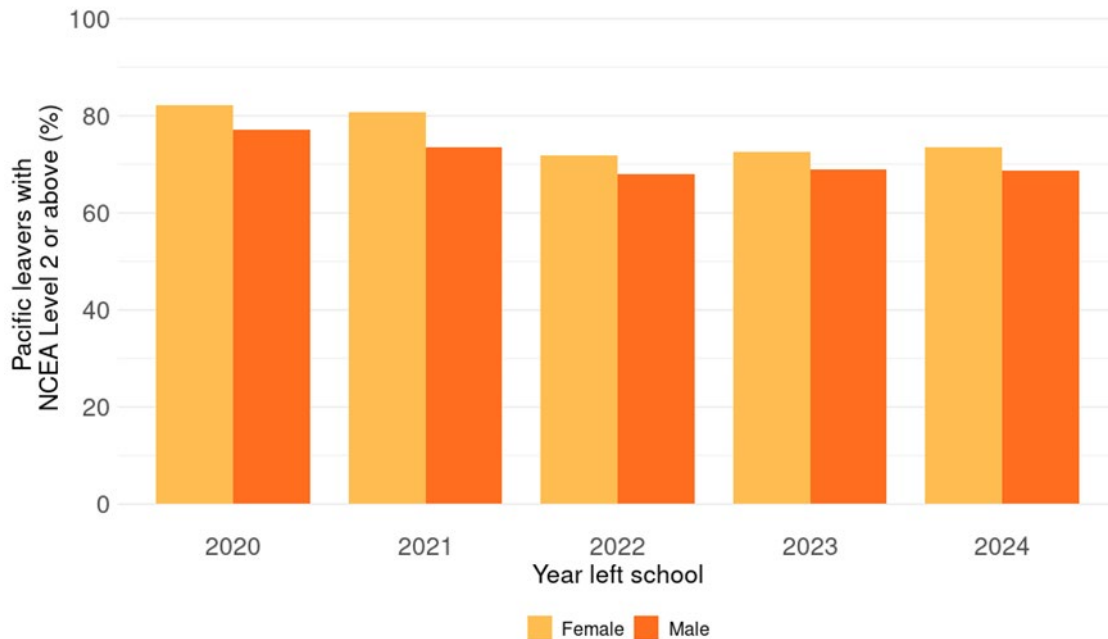
Figure 9: Pacific school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above increased in 2024



In 2024, 73.5% of Pacific female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 68.8% of Pacific male school leavers, up 1.0 percentage point for females and down 0.2 percentage points for males from 2023. The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between females and males experiences greater fluctuation but is almost similar to what it was in 2020 (5.0 percentage points in 2020 compared to 4.7 percentage points in 2024). As shown in Figure 10, the attainment rates for females are higher than the rates for males over the period from 2020 to 2024.



Figure 10: The gap in attainment between female and male Pacific school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above over the period from 2020 to 2024

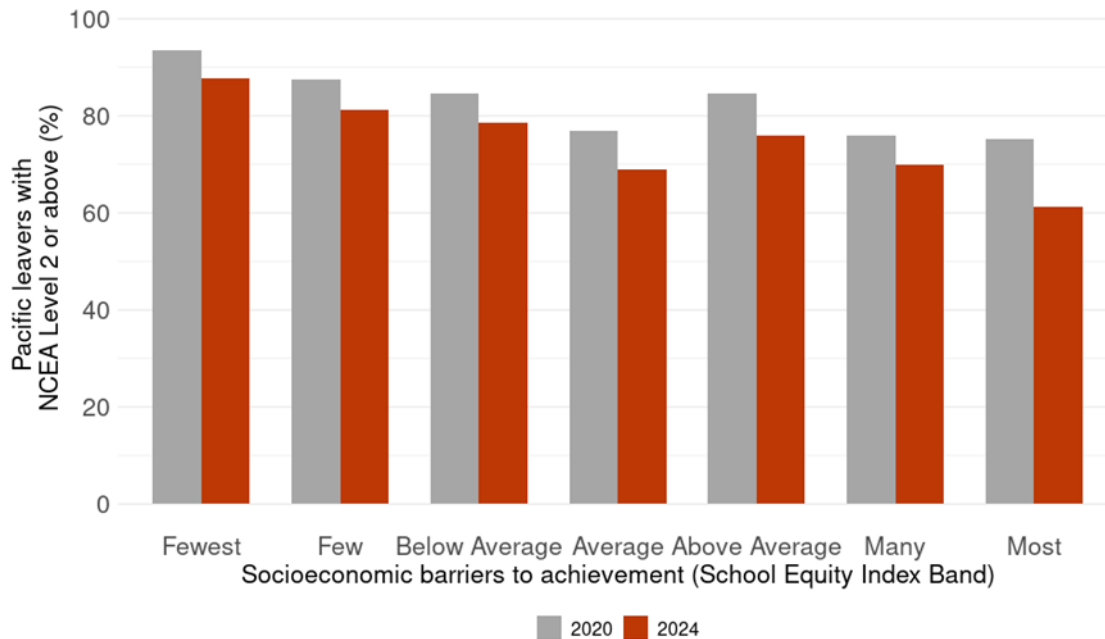


Pacific school leavers from schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement are more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above. In 2024, 87.8% of Pacific leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 compared to 61.3% of Pacific leavers from schools where students have most barriers to achievement. Across all School Equity Index Bands, NCEA Level 2 or above attainment in 2024 was lower than in 2020 as shown in Figure 11.

While the 5-year range from 2020 to 2024 shows that attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above has declined from 2020 to 2024, Figure 11 also shows that these declines have been the highest for leavers in schools where students have most barriers to achievement. Between 2020 and 2024, the attainment rate for Pacific leavers from schools where students have the most barriers decreased by 13.9 percentage points compared to 5.8 percentage points for Pacific leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers.



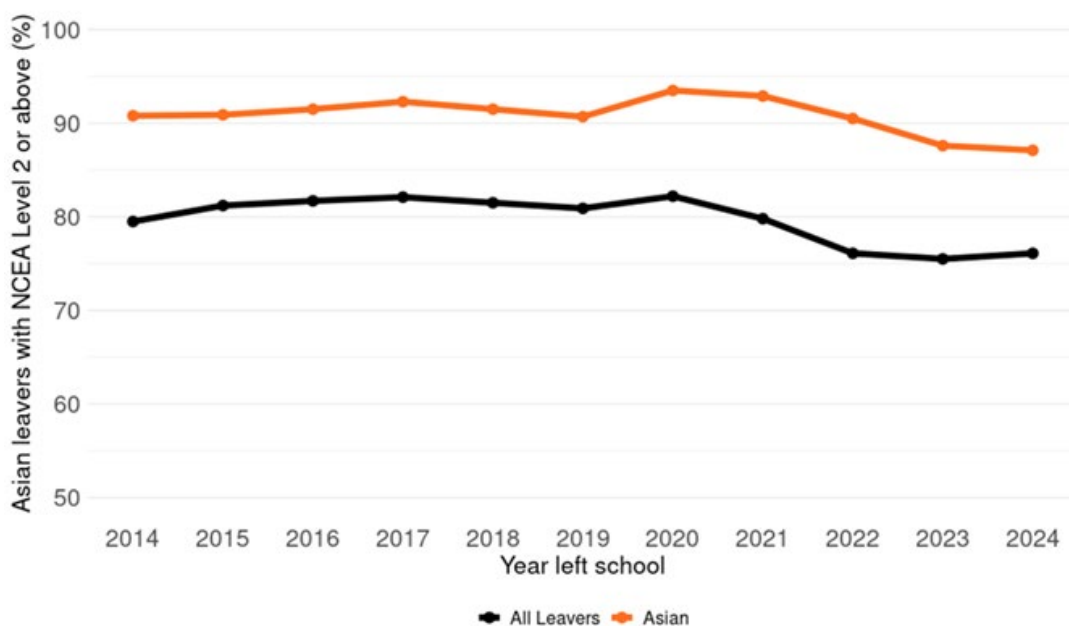
Figure 11: Pacific school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands between 2020 and 2024



Asian school leavers

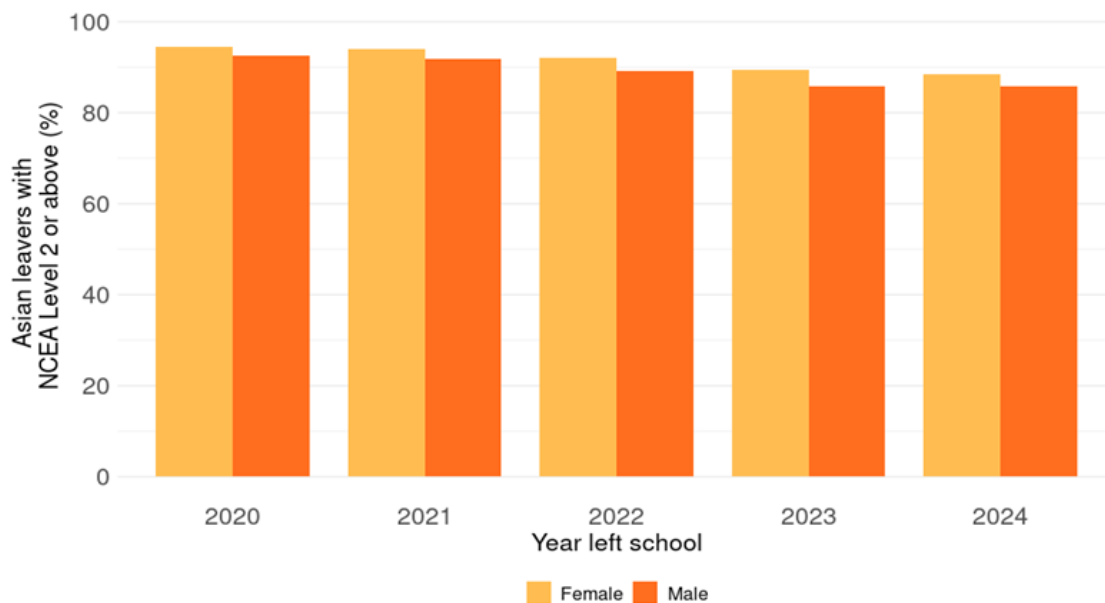
School leavers who identify with an Asian ethnicity have the highest NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rate. The attainment rate for Asian leavers is stable with smaller fluctuations. In 2024, 87.1% of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above, down 0.5 percentage points from in 2023 (see Figure 12). Between 2020 (the peak attainment for Asian leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 6.4 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 3.6 percentage points.

Figure 12: A high proportion of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above



In 2024, 88.4% of Asian female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 85.8% of Asian male school leavers. While these rates are high, they are the lowest rates for both Asian females and males since 2014. Since 2020, Asian female leavers had higher NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates compared to Asian male leavers (Figure 13). The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between Asian females and males has increased, from 2.1 percentage points in 2020, to 3.5 percentage points in 2023 before narrowing again to 2.6 percentage points in 2024.

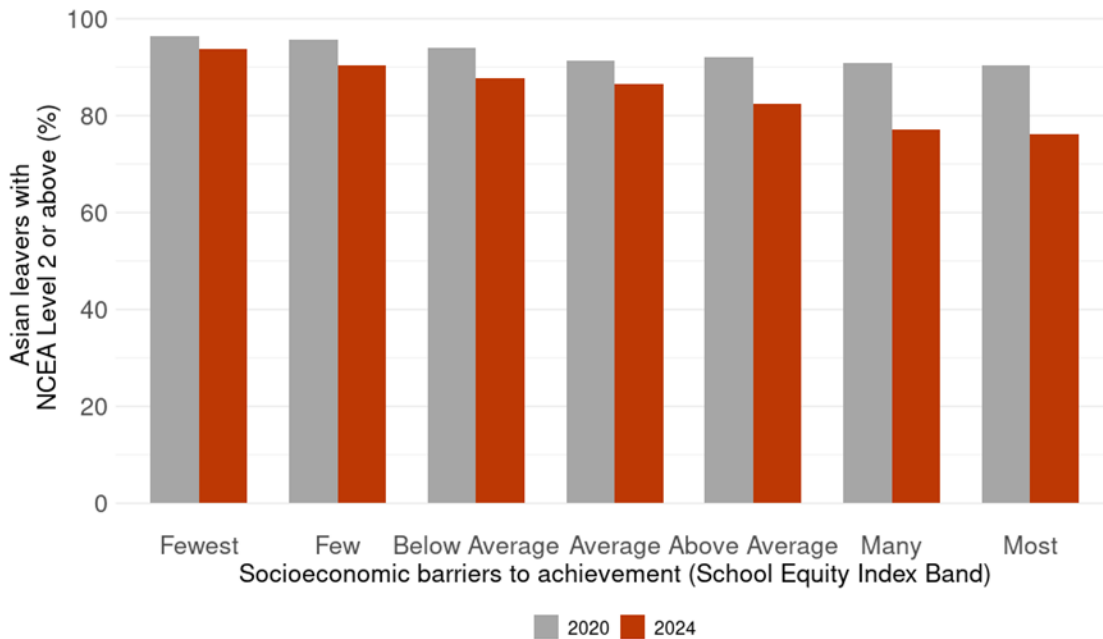
Figure 13: Asian female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above



The gradient effect between socioeconomic barriers and school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above is smaller for Asian school leavers as shown in Figure 14. In 2024, Asian school leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 or above have the highest attainment 93.8%. However, the NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rate for Asian school leavers is higher than the national average in all bands. Asian school leavers from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 76.3% which is 17.2 percentage points higher than the national average rate for 2024.



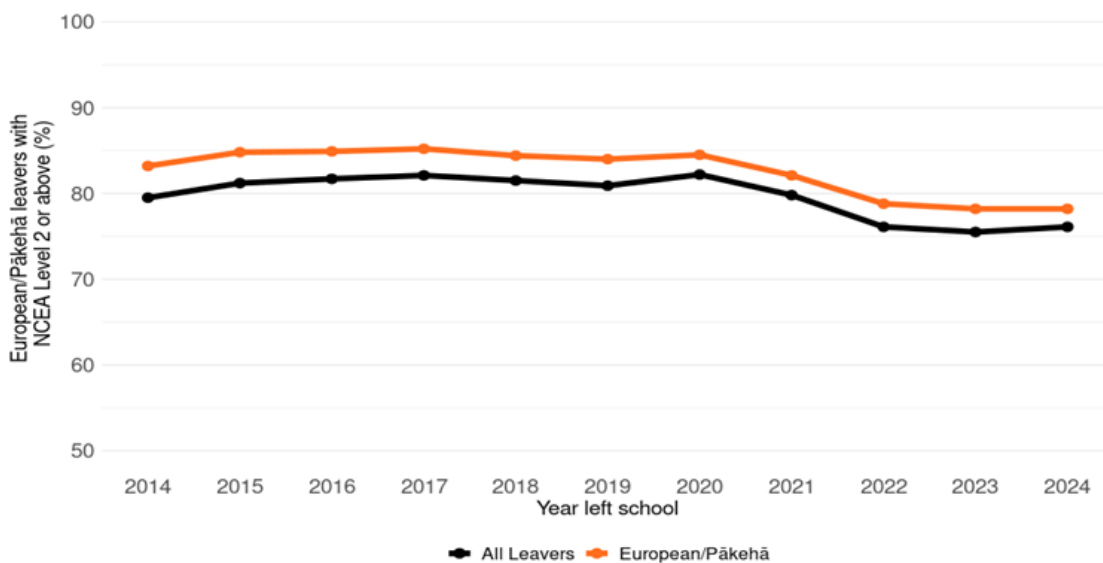
Figure 14: The proportion of Asian school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased since 2020 in all School Equity Index Bands



European/Pākehā school leavers

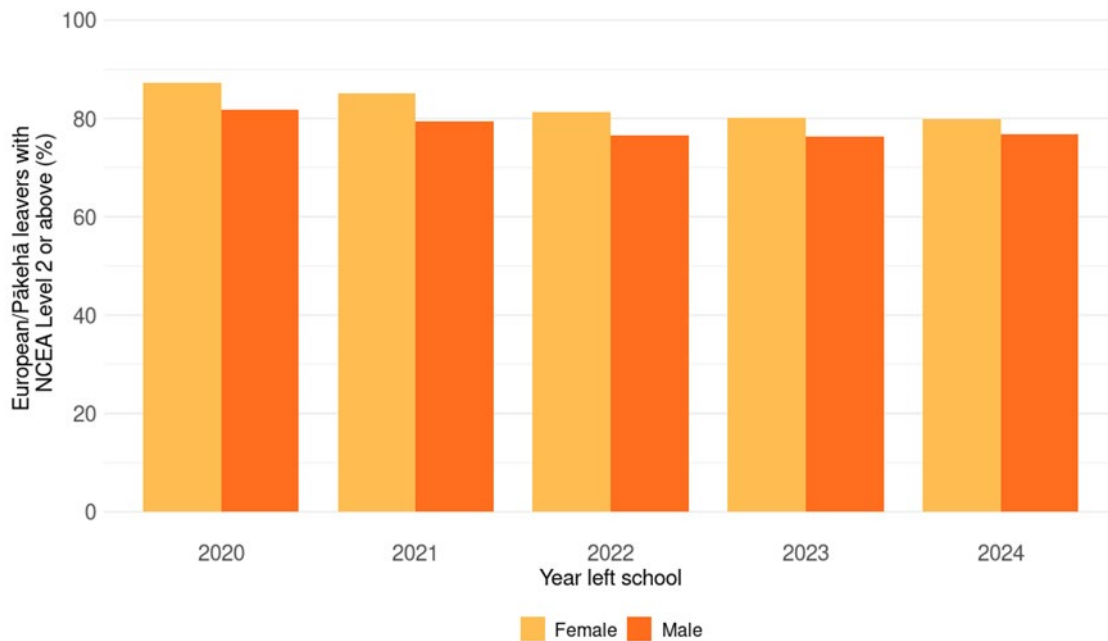
In 2024, 78.2% of European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above, unchanged from 2023. Between 2017 (the peak attainment for European/Pākehā school leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 7.0 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.8 percentage points (see Figure 15).

Figure 15: European/Pākehā school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above is unchanged from 2023



In 2024, 79.8% of European/Pākehā female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 76.7% of European/Pākehā male school leavers. Since 2020, European/Pākehā female leavers had higher NCEA Level 2 attainment rates than European/Pākehā males as shown in Figure 16. The gap in NCEA Level 2 attainment rates between European/Pākehā females and males has decreased from 5.5 percentage points in 2020, to 4.0 percentage points in 2023 and 3.1 percentage points in 2024.

Figure 16: The gender gap for European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased

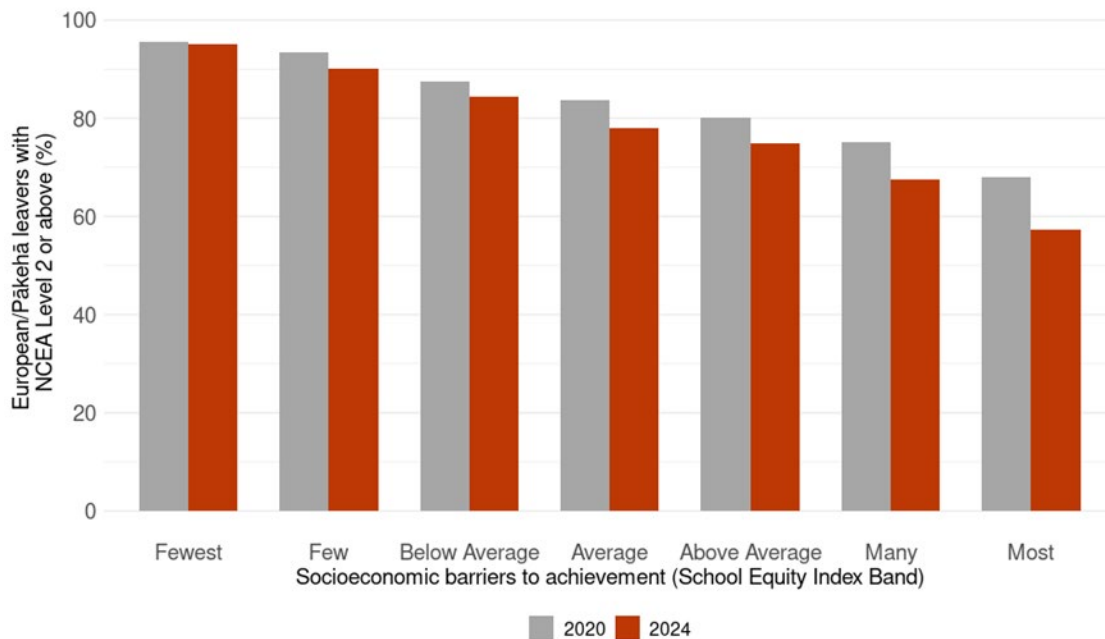


A higher proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers from schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 or above (Figure 17). In 2024, 95% of European/Pākehā from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 57.3% of European/Pākehā from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

Since 2020, the proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased across all equity bands, the largest decrease seen in schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.



Figure 17: Since 2020 the proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 2 or above has decreased



About School Equity Index reporting

The Ministry has developed a new method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics, this new method is called School Equity Index Bands and Groups, derived from the Schooling Equity Index Number. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement.

There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their School Equity Index Number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's Education Counts website [here](#).

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement



Where to find out more

To obtain information about other forms of student disengagement consider indicators:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort - Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)

References

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